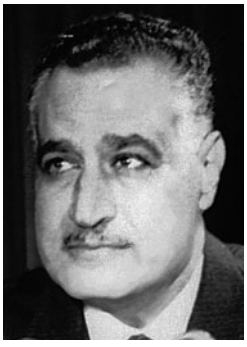

Profile: Gamal Abdul Nasser 1918–70

1918 – Born in Alexandria, in Egypt, the son of a postman
1938 – Graduated as an officer from the military academy
1948 – Fought in the first Arab–Israeli War
1949 – Became a founder of the Free Officers' Movement
1952 – Led the military coup that overthrew the Egyptian monarchy
1954–70 – President of Egypt

Nasser came from a modest background but was able to gain admission to the Egyptian Military Academy. Like several of his fellow young army officers, he was shocked by defeat against Israel in 1948–9 and appalled by the incompetence of King Farouk's government. He led the coup that overthrew the King in 1952 and became leader of the new republican government in Egypt. He set out to strengthen the country and make it completely independent. This meant building up the armed forces and securing the withdrawal of British troops. He achieved this peacefully, but his nationalisation of the Suez Canal provoked an invasion by British, French and Israeli forces. Nevertheless, the British and French were forced to withdraw. Nasser thus emerged as the victor and won fame throughout the Arab world for his defiance of the European powers.

Nasser became the undisputed leader of the Arab world, winning popular support on a scale never achieved before or since by any Arab leader. His speeches, broadcast on Cairo radio, drew millions of listeners and their effect on popular opinion was such that governments in other Arab were often forced to follow Nasser's line. In 1958, the Syrian leaders virtually begged Nasser to join Syria and Egypt together to form the United Arab Republic. Although this union was greeted with euphoria at the start, it only lasted three years. Despite this setback, Nasser's popularity and prestige in the Arab world remained unrivalled for several more years.

Defeat at the hands of the Israelis in 1967 was a heavy blow. The Egyptian armed forces were humiliated, Sinai was lost and the Suez Canal remained closed for several years as the Israelis were encamped on the eastern bank (see page 54). Exhausted, Nasser died of a heart attack in 1970. He was mourned by millions throughout the Arab world.

Key date
Death of Nasser: 1970

The death of Nasser 1970

On the third evening of the Six-Day War in 1967, with the Egyptian air force smashed and the army in retreat, Nasser announced that he would resign. Public opinion demanded that he stay. He was well loved, as well as a very dominant leader, and would not be allowed to leave office in the midst of crisis. Nevertheless, Egypt's defeat in the war was a humiliation for Nasser and for the whole Arab world. Although Egypt's army and air force were replenished by Soviet weapons, Egypt was severely